

43

Kaggle

The world's biggest data science community
Free GPUs, datasets, competitions, and learning

[AI/ML Engineer Learning Series · Deep Dive Edition](#)

What it is	A platform and community for data science
Offers	Free GPUs, datasets, notebooks, competitions
Cost	Free
Great for	Practice, learning, and your portfolio
You use it	Built your Twitter Sentiment project here

What's Inside

Here is everything covered in this guide, in order:

#	Section	What you'll learn
1	What is Kaggle?	The data science hub
2	What You Get — Free	Datasets, GPUs, notebooks
3	Free GPUs	Train models at no cost
4	Competitions	How they work
5	Datasets and Notebooks	Practise on real data
6	The Progression Tiers	Novice to Grandmaster
7	Kaggle for Your Portfolio	Standing out to employers
8	Competitions for Your Roadmap	Matched to your projects
9	Common Mistakes	What to avoid
★	Cheatsheet	Quick reference

1. What is Kaggle?

Kaggle is the world's largest community and platform for data science and machine learning, owned by Google. It's a place to learn, practise, compete, and share — all in one website, and almost entirely free. Millions of data scientists use it, from total beginners to world experts.

You already know Kaggle — you built your Twitter Airline Sentiment project right there, in a Kaggle notebook with free GPUs. This topic steps back to show everything Kaggle offers and how to use it to grow your skills and portfolio as you job-hunt.

■ *Kaggle is one of the best free resources for a self-taught ML engineer like you. Free GPUs, real datasets, and a huge community to learn from — it removes the cost barriers that usually slow people down.*

2. What You Get — Free

Kaggle bundles together everything you need to do machine learning, at no cost. Here's the full toolkit.

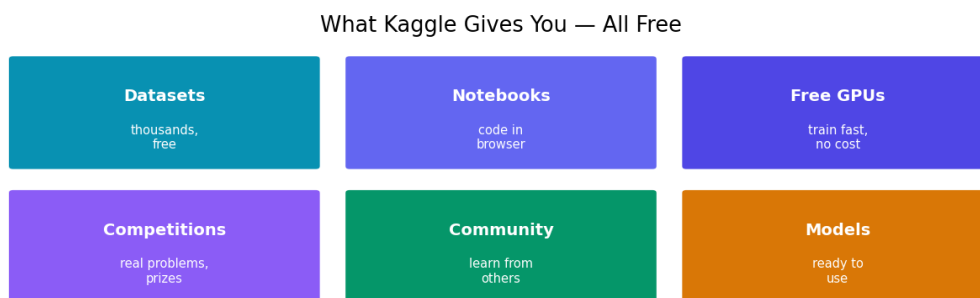


Fig 1 — Everything Kaggle offers — datasets, notebooks, free GPUs, competitions, community, and models — all free.

What	Why it's useful
Datasets	Thousands of free, ready-to-use datasets
Notebooks	Write and run code in the browser — no setup
Free GPUs	Train deep learning models without buying hardware
Competitions	Solve real problems, sometimes for prizes
Community	Learn from others' shared code and discussions
Models	Pre-trained models ready to use

3. Free GPUs

This is Kaggle's most valuable gift for a learner. Deep learning needs GPUs to train in reasonable time, and GPUs are expensive. Kaggle gives you powerful GPUs for free, every week, right in your browser. No setup, no cost.

You used this directly: your Twitter Sentiment project ran on Kaggle's dual T4 GPUs. That's hardware that would cost a lot to rent or buy, available free for your experiments. For training CNNs, fine-tuning models, or any deep learning work, this removes the single biggest barrier for self-learners.

■ *Kaggle gives a weekly quota of free GPU hours. It's perfect for training models for your portfolio projects — the same way you trained your sentiment models. Google Colab is a similar free option worth knowing too.*

4. Competitions

Competitions are Kaggle's famous feature. Companies and researchers post a real problem with data, and anyone can build a model to solve it. Your predictions are scored automatically, and you see your rank on a public leaderboard against everyone else.



Fig 2 — A competition: get the data, build a model, make predictions, submit, and see your rank.

Competitions are a fantastic way to learn. You work on genuine problems, push to improve your score, and — best of all — see how top competitors solved the same task (they often share their code). It's like learning from the best in the world for free. You don't need to win; even entering and improving teaches you a lot and looks great on a portfolio.

■ *Don't aim to win at first — aim to learn. Pick a competition, make a basic submission, then improve it step by step. Reading the top shared notebooks teaches you techniques you won't find in courses.*

5. Datasets and Notebooks

Beyond competitions, Kaggle has two everyday tools you'll use constantly: datasets and notebooks.

Datasets

Thousands of free datasets on every topic — images, text, tables, audio. Instead of hunting for data, you search Kaggle, find a dataset, and start working. Many of your projects can begin with a Kaggle dataset (your Product Image Classifier used a fashion images dataset, for example).

Notebooks

A Kaggle notebook is like a Jupyter notebook that runs in your browser, with the free GPUs attached. No installation, no setup — just open and code. You can attach any dataset, write your model, train it on the GPU, and share the notebook publicly as part of your portfolio.

■ *Public Kaggle notebooks are a portfolio asset: they show your code, your thinking, and your results in one shareable link. A clean, well-explained notebook is something you can link from your CV alongside your GitHub.*

6. The Progression Tiers

Kaggle has a fun ranking system that rewards your contributions. As you compete, share notebooks, and join discussions, you climb through tiers — from Novice up to the rare Grandmaster.

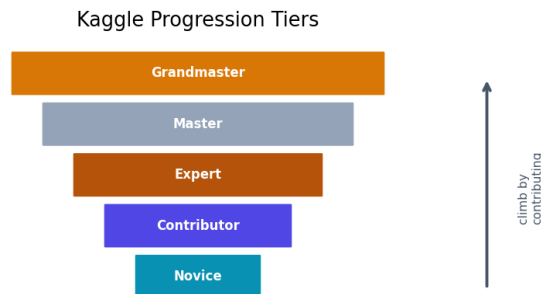


Fig 3 — Kaggle's tiers, from Novice to Grandmaster — you climb by contributing and performing well.

There are separate tiers for competitions, notebooks, datasets, and discussions. You earn medals for good work, and enough medals move you up a tier. It's motivating and gives you a visible track record. Reaching Expert tier is a realistic, impressive goal that signals real skill to employers.

7. Kaggle for Your Portfolio

Kaggle is a powerful, free way to strengthen your profile as you job-hunt. It gives you concrete, verifiable proof of your skills — exactly what a self-taught engineer needs to stand out.

Do this on Kaggle	Why it helps your job search
Enter a competition	Shows you tackle real problems
Share clean notebooks	Public proof of your coding skill
Earn a tier (e.g. Expert)	A visible, credible track record
Publish a dataset	Shows initiative and data skills
Reference projects on your CV	Linkable, verifiable work

For someone without a CS degree, Kaggle is a great equaliser — it judges your work, not your background. A solid Kaggle profile with shared notebooks and a competition or two gives recruiters real evidence of your ability. Link it alongside your GitHub and portfolio site.

8. Competitions for Your Roadmap

Smartly chosen, a Kaggle competition can double as a portfolio project that matches your roadmap. Here are competitions that line up with projects you're building.



Fig 4 — Competitions that map directly onto the projects on your roadmap.

Competition	Maps to your project
Severstal: Steel Defect Detection	Your Visual Defect Detector
Global Wheat Detection	Your YOLOv8 object detection project
LLM Science Exam	A RAG / LLM extension project

The smart strategy: pick a competition that matches a project you're already building. You get a real dataset, a clear goal, a leaderboard to measure against, and top notebooks to learn from — all while building a portfolio piece. Two birds, one stone.

9. Common Mistakes

Mistake	Why it's a problem	Fix
Trying to win immediately	Discouraging, unrealistic	Aim to learn and improve
Not reading top notebooks	Miss the best techniques	Study shared solutions
Ignoring GPU quota	Run out mid-training	Turn GPU on only when needed
Never sharing work	No portfolio benefit	Publish clean notebooks
Overfitting the leaderboard	Looks good, learns little	Focus on solid methods
Working in isolation	Slower learning	Use the community and discussions

Quick Reference Cheatsheet

Concept	Meaning
Kaggle	biggest data science community (free)
Notebook	browser-based Jupyter with free GPU
Dataset	free, ready-to-use data
Competition	real problem, scored leaderboard
Free GPUs	weekly quota for training (e.g. T4)
Leaderboard	your rank vs everyone
Tiers	Novice -> Contributor -> Expert -> Master -> Grandmaster
Medals	earned for good work, raise your tier
Portfolio use	share notebooks, enter competitions
Severstal	matches your Defect Detector
Global Wheat	matches your object detection
Strategy	pick competitions that match your projects

The one idea to remember: Kaggle gives you free GPUs, datasets, notebooks, and real competitions — everything a self-taught ML engineer needs to practise and prove their skills. Use it to build portfolio projects that match your roadmap and show employers verifiable work.

Next Topic: Hosting Your AI — the final topic: putting your projects online for the world using the OpenAI API, Hugging Face Spaces, and Render. The last step from your machine to a live, shareable app.